

Arts and Crafts

Instigated by the writings of John Ruskin and the beliefs of designer, writer and activist William Morris (1834–96), the Arts and Crafts movement began in Britain in the 1860s, before sweeping across Europe and North America. Aiming to reform art and design to improve society, it particularly opposed the cheapness and poor design of mass-produced goods that were the result of the Industrial Revolution, supporting products that were made by designers who took pride in their work, using quality materials and simple designs based on nature.

In 1861, Morris co-founded a firm of interior decorators and manufacturers. Known after 1875 as Morris & Co, it was dedicated to recapturing the careful workmanship of medieval crafts, hand-producing metalwork, jewellery, wallpaper, textiles, ceramics, furniture and stained glass. In 1890, he also established the Kelmscott Press to publish quality editions of contemporary and historical English literature. Ultimately however, most people could not afford such costly, hand-made goods.



Morris, design for *Trellis* wallpaper, 1862